

HD-DFIR-001 — Windows Workstation Investigation

Classification: Simulated training case / portfolio-safe

Incident Brief

A finance workstation was reported for unusual after-hours activity. You have been provided a focused logical forensic collection. Determine what occurred using only the supplied evidence. Do not assume that every artifact is suspicious.

Known Information

Hostname: FIN-WS17

Collection scope: selected user, browser, event-export, shortcut, and system artifacts

Timezone for this exercise: UTC

Evidence is synthetic; no real organization or person is represented.

Questions to Answer

1. Which user account was involved in the after-hours activity?
2. What is the earliest defensible timestamp for the suspicious sequence?
3. Which potentially sensitive file became relevant to the investigation?
4. Was removable storage involved? Identify the device and supporting evidence.
5. Was a utility obtained or executed during the sequence? What evidence supports your conclusion?
6. Is there evidence suggesting data left the workstation? Separate direct evidence from inference.
7. Construct a concise timeline of the key events.
8. State at least two limitations or alternative explanations.

Rules

Start in Autopsy. Registry Explorer is optional and should only be used if you identify a registry hive worth validating. Record the artifact path and timestamp for every finding. Do not search online for a case solution; there is none.

Deliverable

Prepare an evidence-backed case summary containing an executive summary, evidence examined, findings, timeline, conclusions, and limitations. Screenshots may be used in the final GitHub/LinkedIn case study after review.